KARNATAKA: FURORE OVER WAQF LAND PG 9

AMARAVATI RISES AGAIN PG 12

UPFRONT

A MAHA KUMBH CHALLENGE PG 12

TELANGANA: A BOLD CASTE COUNT MOVE PG 16



THE BUCK STOPS HERE? N. Biren Singh, Chief Minister, Manipur

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

MANIPUR CRISIS

BIREN IN TAPE TROUBLE

By Kaushik Deka

In a significant legal and political development, the Supreme Court has agreed to examine audio recordings that allegedly implicate Manipur chief minister N. Biren Singh in the violent ethnic conflict between the Meitei and Kuki communities that erupted in the northeastern state in May last year. The decision marks a crucial step in the court's oversight of one of India's most volatile state crises, where months of unrest have left more than 230 people dead, some 60,000 displaced and communities sharply polarised. Sporadic incidents of violence being reported from rural pockets still threaten peace.

The case, brought by the Kuki Organisation for Human Rights Trust (KOHRT), has as its basis recordings from a purported closed-door meeting in which Singh can be allegedly heard admitting to supporting the sectarian violence, encouraging the looting of arms and providing protection to those involved in militant activities. The court's probe into these tapes could have profound implications not only for the political landscape of Manipur but also for the broader question of accountability in public office.

The audio recordings first surfaced in mid-2024, igniting a firestorm that only grew as the clips circulated on social media and in news reports. Their purported origins date back to a meeting at the chief minister's official residence, reportedly held in the latter part of 2023. The whistleblower, whose